

Japan Equity Style Investing

Stay with AI Momentum, Hedge a Hawkish BOJ Hike with Value-Momentum

- Japanese equities strengthened in May as risk-on sentiment accelerated on the back of easing geopolitical risk and a further intensification of the global AI semiconductor boom. In line with record highs across major global equity markets, the Nikkei 225 rose sharply into early June, approaching the 68,000 level. While the rally was significantly supported by semiconductor-related names with large index weights, style performance also confirmed a broader pro-risk bias, with Beta, Momentum, and Size, particularly Large Cap, outperforming.
- Global optimism toward AI semiconductors continued to support Japanese equities on a smoothed basis, despite intermittent pullbacks driven by short-term overextension. In Japan, not only core semiconductor and semiconductor production equipment names, but also AI infrastructure-related stocks posted notable gains. The earnings contribution from the global surge in semiconductor demand remains a key driver. As a result, even when mini-crashes in Momentum occur, fundamental investors have tended to buy the dips before selling pressure from speculative accounts becomes prolonged. This has helped limit downside pressure.
- At the same time, **while AI-related names continue to benefit from medium-term Momentum support, concerns are increasing over the excessive polarization that has developed in the market.** With investors pricing in an additional BOJ rate hike in June, some have begun to question the persistent underperformance of Value stocks. Within Value, there are also a number of names that carry a reasonable degree of Momentum. As such, in a short-term rotation away from AI Momentum names, Value with Momentum characteristics could become an attractive destination for flows.
- Our proprietary Japan QMI improved month-over-month in May and remained in Expansion territory by definition. Although higher commodity prices stemming from the Strait of Hormuz closure have affected parts of the domestic non-manufacturing sector, manufacturing has shown greater-than-expected resilience, led by AI-related demand. The global capex cycle also remains on an upswing, contributing to the improvement in Japan QMI. That said, the recent pace of improvement partly reflects one-off tailwinds such as special demand in memory, and statistically, maintaining the current pace of acceleration appears challenging. Looking into the summer, our base case remains that investors should keep potential cyclical deceleration in mind and remain alert to overheating in the Beta effect.
- From June onward, we expect the AI semiconductor-led market structure to remain broadly intact, while periodic reversals are likely. However, investors should also prepare for two risks: insufficient pricing of a potentially more hawkish-than-expected BOJ rate hike, and a partial correction of the extreme polarization between winning and losing sectors. In that context, **we would pay closer attention to the overlap between Value and Momentum, where laggards may become a recipient of hedging-related flows.**

Global Quantitative and Derivatives Strategy

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Figure 1: Japan Equity Style Assessments for June

Changes from the prior quarter (Q1 2026) are highlighted in red (there may be none)

Styles		Value	Growth	Quality	Low Vol	High Beta	Size (L-Smid)	Momentum
Overall Japan Views		OW	UW	OW on Mid caps	UW	N	OW on Mid caps	Selective OW
Cycle (QMI)	Exp -> Slowing	EV/EBITDA	Earning Mom	Buy	UW	N	OW	Sticky
Position	Mild heavy	Mild-Heavy	Less Heavy	Less Heavy	Light	Heavy	Concentrated	Heavy
Themes	Themes affecting JPN	Inflation/ROIC>WACC/BOJ Hike	Quality-competitions/AI	Takaichi's Industrial Policy/AI	Defensive	Offensives	Concentration/Passive flows	Concentration on AI-related names

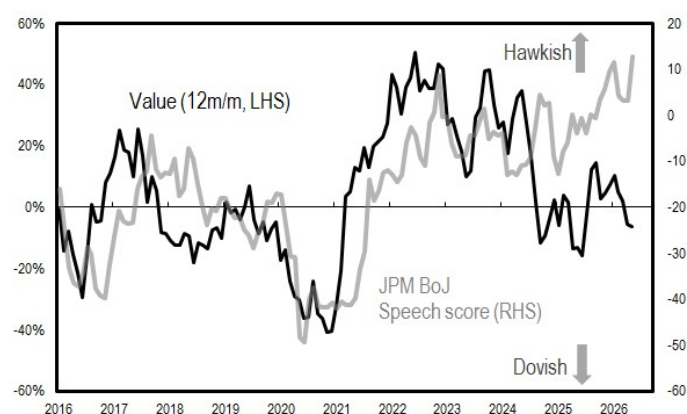
Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 2: Key Summary of Japan Style for May

Factor	May	Apr	Mar	Sharpe Last 12 Months
Momentum	6.4%	14.1%	-12.9%	0.44
Size (L-S)	6.3%	13.3%	-4.0%	0.68
Beta (High)	6.2%	25.9%	-8.6%	0.74
Earnings Growth	3.7%	13.7%	-5.9%	0.32
Price to Book	0.8%	-10.5%	4.5%	0.17
Earnings Yield	-2.3%	-18.7%	0.6%	0.00
Div Yield	-5.9%	-14.1%	9.9%	-0.03
ROE	-8.9%	5.5%	4.2%	-0.21
JPM Quality	-10.3%	5.0%	5.7%	-0.27
Q-Score	-10.5%	10.2%	-6.7%	0.37
Low Vol	-11.1%	-23.6%	9.9%	-0.50

Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 3: Key Chart - Value Performance Isn't Priced for a BoJ Rate Hike



Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 4: Value stocks with moderate momentum (upside) effect as of 8 June

1. Universe: MSXJP constituents. 2. Mechanically selected based on each name's factor loadings (as of last month-end). 3. We first select stocks in the top 50% by Momentum factor loading (positive values only). From that subset, we choose the 30 names with the highest Value factor loading.

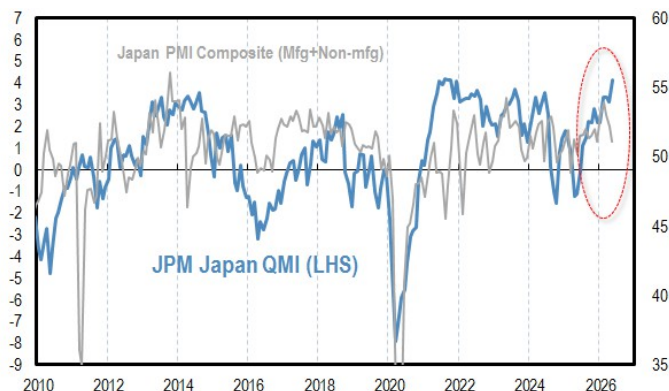
Code	Name	Sector(TSE33)	mkt cap (bn¥)	Price (¥)	3m Ret% (Absl)	12m Ret% (Absl)	3m Ret% (vs. TPX)	12m Ret% (vs. TPX)	Beta	P/E (12m fwd)	P/B (LTM)	ROE (LTM)	DivYld% (LTM)
9503	KANSAI ELEC PWR	Electric Power & Gas	2,576	2,311	-10%	38%	-14%	1%	0.9	8.7	0.7	11.7	3.5
7259	AISIN CORP	Transportation Equipment	1,714	2,361	-3%	29%	-7%	-8%	1.1	9.8	0.8	8.2	3.2
5019	IDEMITSU KOSAN C	Oil & Coal Products	1,650	1,349	-6%	51%	-10%	14%	0.8	10.3	0.9	9.4	2.7
8473	SBI HOLDINGS INC	Securities & Commodity Futures	1,871	2,831	-6%	20%	-10%	-17%	1.3	8.7	1.0	28.0	3.4
7181	JAPAN POST INSUR	Insurance	1,623	1,455	-8%	33%	-12%	-5%	1.0	9.5	0.4	4.6	3.4
9502	CHUBU ELEC POWER	Electric Power & Gas	2,028	2,675	6%	52%	1%	15%	0.6	11.2	0.6	7.7	2.6
9104	MITSUI OSK LINES	Marine Transportation	2,094	5,767	-8%	19%	-12%	-18%	0.8	10.7	0.7	7.7	3.6
8725	MS&AD INSURANCE	Insurance	6,570	4,402	8%	35%	3%	-2%	1.2	9.2	1.3	18.0	3.2
8630	SOMPO HOLDINGS I	Insurance	5,598	5,992	1%	33%	-3%	-4%	1.2	10.0	1.0	13.7	3.3
5020	ENEOS HOLDINGS I	Oil & Coal Products	3,383	1,250	-9%	70%	-13%	32%	1.1	9.9	1.0	8.0	2.7
8593	MITSUBISHI HC CA	Other Financing Business	1,905	1,299	-11%	24%	-15%	-14%	0.8	10.6	0.9	8.6	3.9
1605	INPEX CORP	Mining	4,585	3,641	-13%	69%	-17%	31%	0.8	9.0	0.9	7.9	3.0
9531	TOKYO GAS CO LTD	Electric Power & Gas	2,114	6,311	-18%	30%	-22%	-7%	0.5	16.2	1.2	13.2	1.9
3003	HULIC CO LTD	Real Estate	1,288	1,677	-14%	13%	-19%	-24%	0.6	10.0	1.4	13.3	4.0
8750	DAIICHI LIFE GRO	Insurance	6,040	1,668	13%	52%	9%	15%	1.2	12.5	1.4	11.3	4.3
8601	DAIWA SECS GRP	Securities & Commodity Futures	2,410	1,536	2%	51%	-2%	14%	1.2	12.4	1.2	10.3	4.2
8604	NOMURA HOLDINGS	Securities & Commodity Futures	4,199	1,360	10%	48%	6%	11%	1.4	10.5	1.1	10.1	3.8
9107	KAWASAKI KISEN	Marine Transportation	1,728	2,703	0%	31%	-4%	-6%	1.0	15.4	0.9	7.7	4.4
6178	JAPAN POST HOLDI	Services	5,976	2,128	14%	58%	10%	21%	1.1	13.4	0.6	4.0	2.8
2503	KIRIN HOLDINGS C	Foods	2,155	2,642	0%	29%	-4%	-9%	0.4	12.2	1.6	12.4	2.9
9532	OSAKA GAS CO LTD	Electric Power & Gas	2,195	5,516	-13%	48%	-17%	11%	0.6	14.4	1.2	8.7	2.4
5201	AGC INC	Glass & Ceramics Products	1,569	7,214	20%	67%	16%	30%	0.9	17.0	1.0	6.0	2.9
3407	ASAHI KASEI CORP	Chemicals	2,385	1,746	2%	79%	-2%	42%	0.9	14.0	1.1	8.0	2.5
8309	SUMITOMO MITSUI	Banks	4,043	5,786	13%	51%	9%	14%	1.1	11.1	1.1	9.5	0.8
6326	KUBOTA CORP	Machinery	3,135	2,754	0%	71%	-5%	34%	1.0	13.5	1.2	8.6	1.9
4503	ASTELLAS PHARMA	Pharmaceutical	3,889	2,149	-13%	56%	-17%	19%	0.6	10.8	2.1	17.4	3.7
7912	DAI NIPPON PRINT	Other Products	1,155	2,628	-15%	22%	-19%	-15%	0.8	11.5	1.0	8.9	1.6
4188	MITSUBISHI CHEMI	Chemicals	1,490	1,034	7%	35%	2%	-2%	1.0	13.4	0.8	0.7	3.1
4507	SHIONOGI & CO	Pharmaceutical	2,531	2,845	-18%	14%	-22%	-23%	0.6	10.5	1.4	13.5	2.7
1802	OBAYASHI CORP	Construction	2,125	3,071	-23%	37%	-28%	0%	0.9	13.1	1.7	14.4	3.1

Source: FactSet, J.P. Morgan

Market cycle (top down)

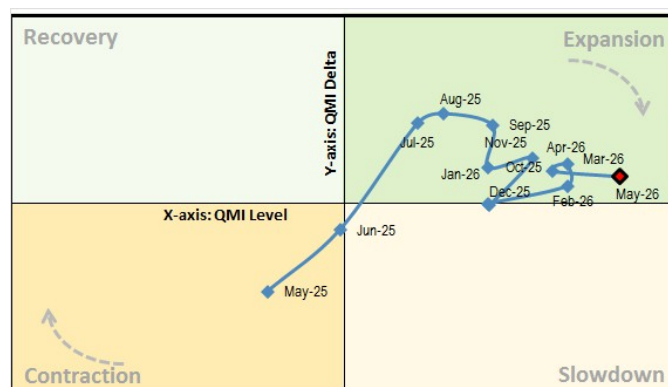
Japan QMI remained in Expansion territory in May. Against the backdrop of the global AI boom, real activity appears to have improved more than expected in sectors such as semiconductor production equipment and AI infrastructure. The negative impact of Middle East-related tensions, which we have been monitoring since March, has not yet appeared clearly in QMI.

Figure 5: Japan QMI since 2010



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P., MSCI Barra, J.P. Morgan

Figure 6: Japan QMI State Positions for the Past 1 Year



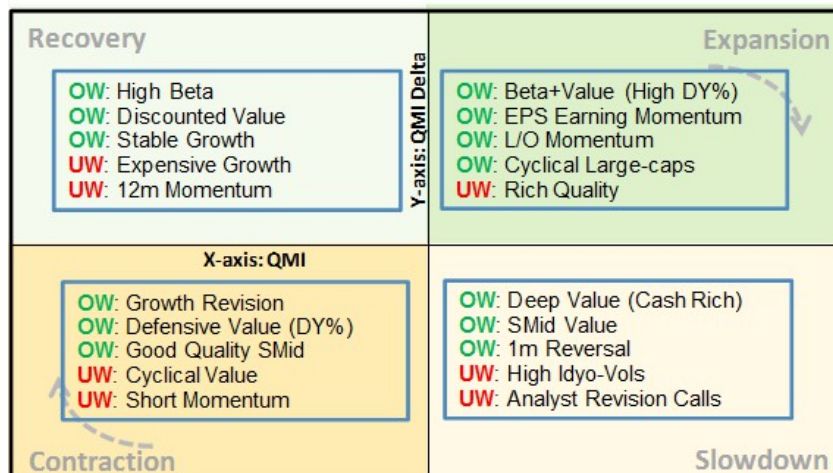
Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P., MSCI Barra, J.P. Morgan

We track QMI across all global regions to determine where each country stands in its cycle. The relationship between Japan's QMI and Style factors is illustrated below.

In an Expansion phase, we favor cyclicals, value, and large caps. We also favor the long side of Momentum. However, given the extended duration of this phase, we note that Beta and Momentum are showing clear signs of overheating. At this stage, positioning for a Slowdown phase still appears to be a minority view.

Figure 7: J.P. Morgan Style Investing – Phases of the Market Cycle with Favored Styles

Based on backtesting from Jan 2000 to Dec 2024.

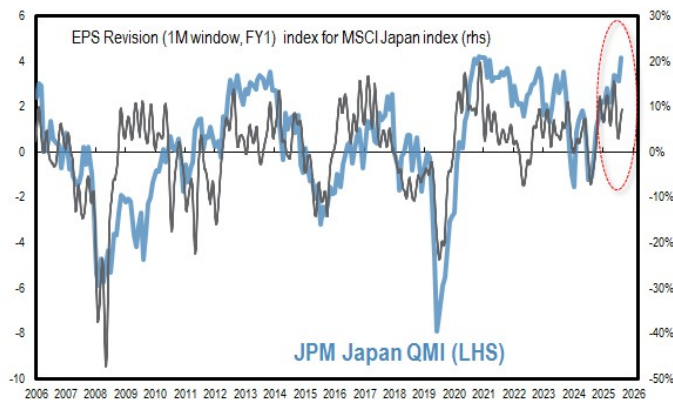


Source: J.P. Morgan

The cyclical and high-beta-led rally in Japanese equities since last June can be explained by improving macro momentum, as measured by QMI, and the associated recovery in corporate earnings expectations. Since the beginning of the year, the global AI semiconductor boom has provided a powerful tailwind to corporate earnings. While the negative effects of the Strait of Hormuz closure have appeared in parts of the domestic non-manufacturing sector, the expansion of the global capex cycle has offset these pressures in manufacturing. As a result, the distinction between winners and losers in the Japanese equity market has become increasingly entrenched, and Momentum has gained further strength amid continued market polarization. From a technical perspective, however, more investors appear to be looking for opportunities to position for a partial correction of this excessive bifurcation.

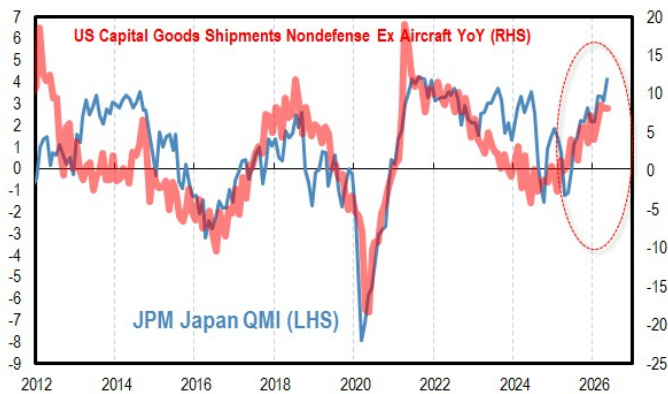
The market has priced in an additional BOJ rate hike in June, and JGB yields remain elevated. Some market participants are concerned that the BOJ could be behind the curve, leaving the risk that the central bank may proceed with a hawkish rate hike focused on containing inflation. To date, AI semiconductor-related names have absorbed upward pressure from interest rates, supported by strong earnings improvement expectations. However, the risk of a hawkish BOJ hike does not appear to be fully priced. This could lead to a temporary cooling of excessive Momentum buying and a reassessment of lagging Value names. In June, we believe it is attractive to maintain a medium-term constructive view on AI Momentum while also focusing on a short-term rebalancing across sectors.

Figure 8: Japan QMI and EPS Revision index (MXJP)



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P., MSCI Barra, J.P. Morgan

Figure 9: Japan QMI and US Capital Goods Shipments



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P., MSCI Barra, J.P. Morgan

Style performance and features

Below we summarize May's style performance landscape.

Figure 10: Summary of the Japan Style Families – Performance and Spreads

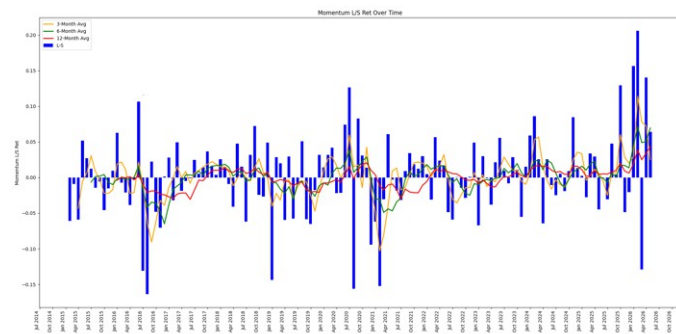
We show the Long-Short monthly returns, then the averages. Vol is the monthly S.D. over 12 months. The spreads indicate how much more the style is exposed to PB or Beta relative to its 10-year average; Green PB Spread = Cheaper than usual. The universe is MSCI Japan (Decile, No Neutralized).

Factor	May	Apr	Mar	Last 3 Months Avg	Last 6 Months Avg	Last 12 Months Avg	Return Vol Last 12 Months	Sharpe Last 12 Months	PB Spread Premium	Beta Spread Premium	Momentum Spread Premium
Momentum	6.4%	14.1%	-12.9%	2.5%	7.0%	4.3%	9.9%	0.44	-0.22	2.18	0.50
Size (L-S)	6.3%	13.3%	-4.0%	5.2%	4.6%	4.2%	6.1%	0.68	-0.21	1.37	0.80
Beta (High)	6.2%	25.9%	-8.6%	7.8%	8.9%	8.3%	11.1%	0.74	-0.53	-0.02	2.49
Earnings Growth	3.7%	13.7%	-5.9%	3.8%	2.8%	1.5%	4.9%	0.32	-0.01	0.41	0.16
Price to Book	0.8%	-10.5%	4.5%	-1.7%	0.5%	1.3%	7.9%	0.17	-0.07	-0.84	-0.38
Earnings Yield	-2.3%	-18.7%	0.6%	-6.8%	-2.8%	0.0%	8.7%	0.00	0.15	-1.19	-1.21
Div Yield	-5.9%	-14.1%	9.9%	-3.4%	0.1%	-0.2%	7.8%	-0.03	0.01	-0.95	-0.57
ROE	-8.9%	5.5%	4.2%	0.3%	-2.5%	-1.4%	6.5%	-0.21	-0.27	-0.11	-0.17
JPM Quality	-10.3%	5.0%	5.7%	0.1%	-1.4%	-1.5%	5.6%	-0.27	-0.19	0.01	-0.42
Q-Score	-10.5%	10.2%	-6.7%	-2.3%	1.6%	2.3%	6.3%	0.37	-0.39	0.57	0.23
Low Vol	-11.1%	-23.6%	9.9%	-8.3%	-6.9%	-5.4%	10.8%	-0.50	0.45	-0.39	-2.01

Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 11: Top Performer Last Month – Momentum

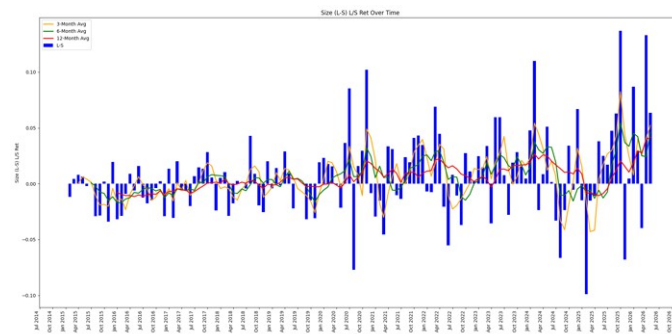
Monthly L/S portfolio performance: %



Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 12: Second-best Performer Last Month –Size (L-S)

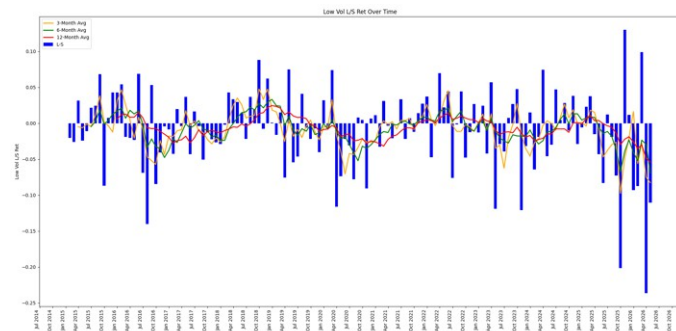
Monthly L/S portfolio performance: %



Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 13: Worst Performer Last Month –Low Vol (Low vs. High Volatility)

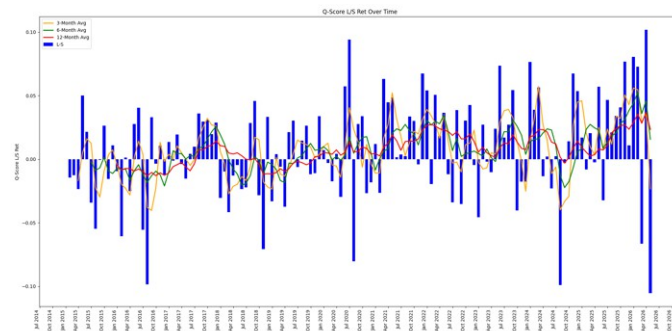
Monthly L/S portfolio performance: %



Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 14: Second-worst Performer Last Month –Q-scores(Multi-factor model)

Monthly L/S portfolio performance: %



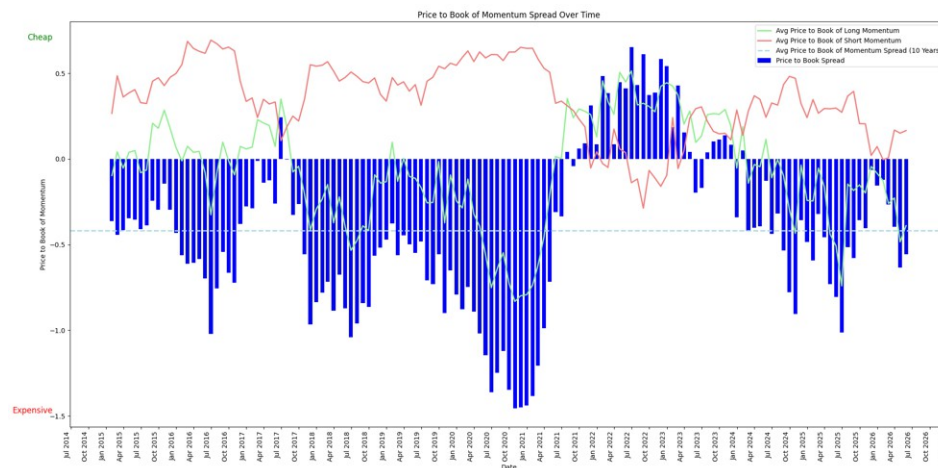
Source: J.P. Morgan

We examine the characteristics of the long-short portfolios for May's best-performing factors, **Momentum** and **Size (L-S)**, as well as the worst-performing factors, **Low Vol** and **Q-score**, from two perspectives: valuation spread (P/B) and risk spread (Beta).

Figure 15: P/B Spread of Momentum (High vs. Low Return)

The Y axis is P/B that is Z-Scored and flipped – the higher the Z-score, the cheaper the L/S portfolio is on P/B.

Momentum's valuation spread remained expensive. Since the beginning of the year, leadership has become increasingly entrenched, and the valuation premium of popular names appears to have continued to widen.

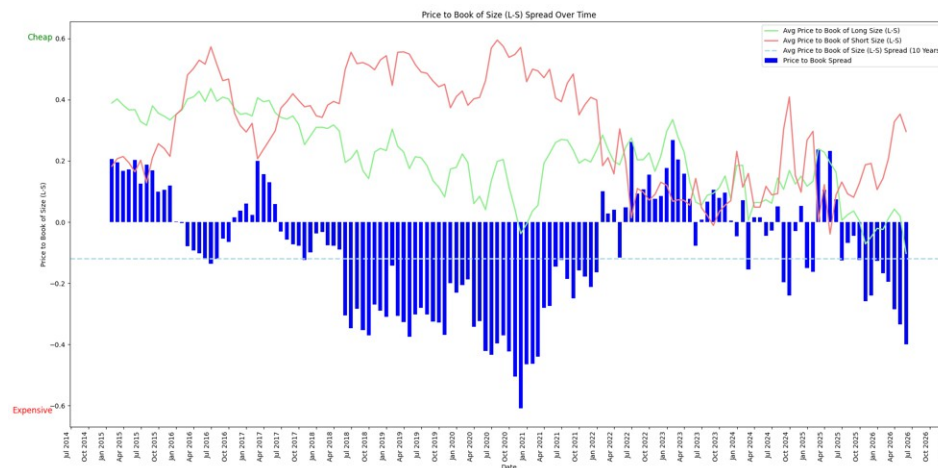


Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 16: P/B Spread of Size (Large vs. SMid caps)

The Y axis is P/B that is Z-Scored and flipped – the higher the Z-score, the cheaper the L/S portfolio is on P/B.

The valuation spread for **Size (L-S)** became more expensive, reaching its highest level since 2021. This suggests that investor preference remains concentrated in large-cap semiconductor-related names.

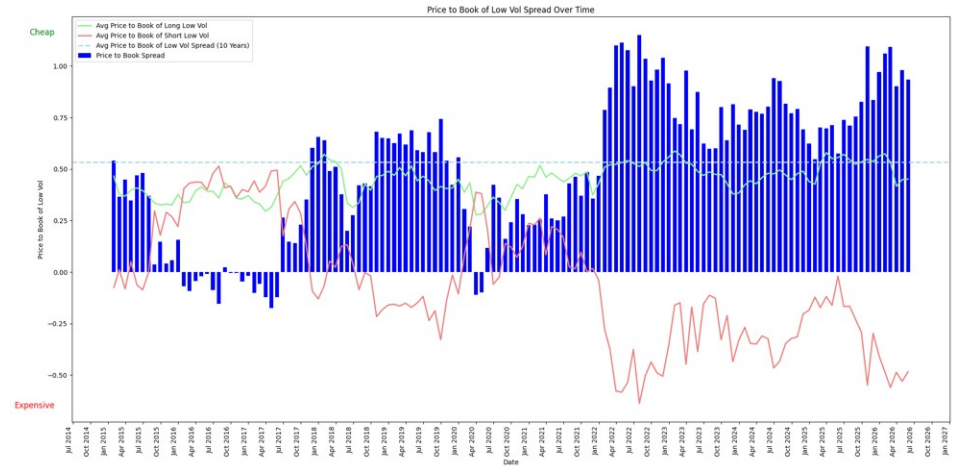


Source: J.P. Morgan

Low Vol's valuation spread became even cheaper relative to its 10-year average, as defensive names continued to underperform

Figure 17: P/B Spread of Low Vol (Low vs. High Volatility)

The Y axis is P/B that is Z-Scored and flipped – the higher the Z-score, the cheaper the L/S portfolio is on P/B.

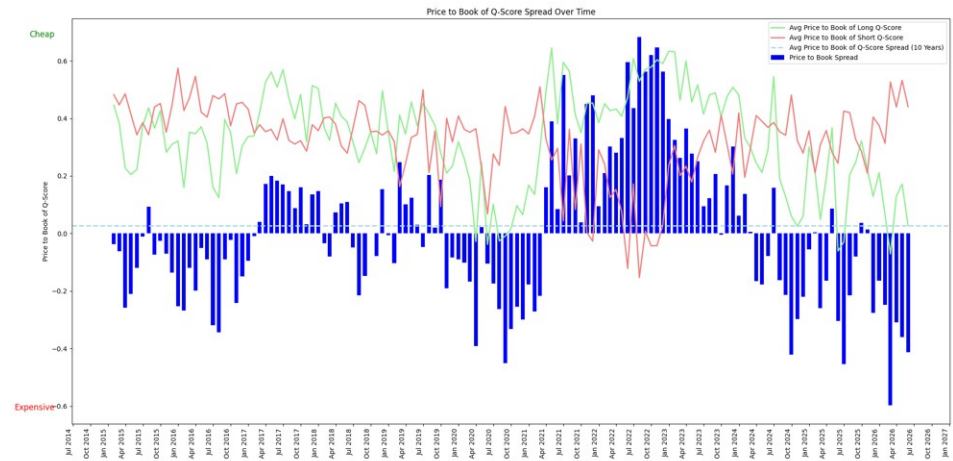


Source: J.P. Morgan

Q-score's valuation spread remained somewhat expensive. The underperformance of the multi-factor style was relatively unusual.

Figure 18: P/B Spread of Q-scores (Multi-factor model)

The Y axis is P/B that is Z-Scored and flipped – the higher the Z-score, the cheaper the L/S portfolio is on P/B.

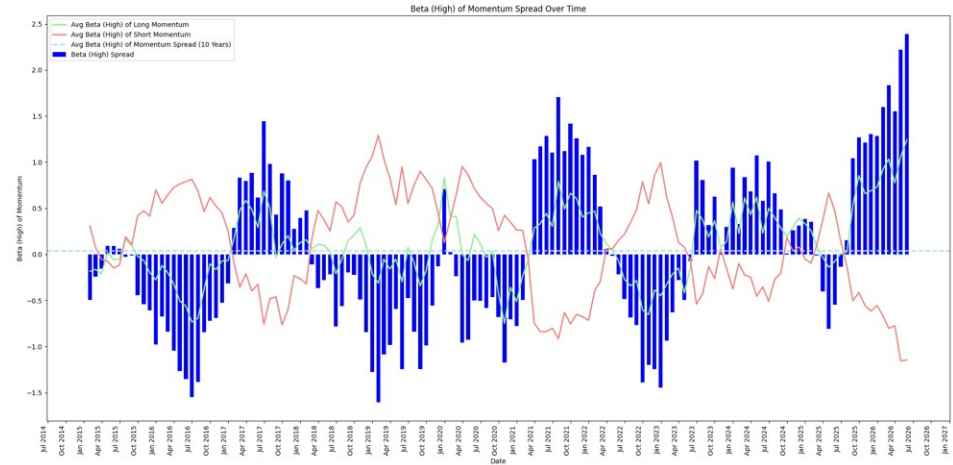


Source: J.P. Morgan

Momentum's risk spread reached a record tilt toward high beta. Low-beta names appear to have been increasingly shorted, while high-beta names were added on the long side.

Figure 19: Beta Spread of Momentum (High vs. Low Return)

The Y axis is Beta that is Z-Scored – the higher the Z-score, the higher the L/S portfolio is on Beta.

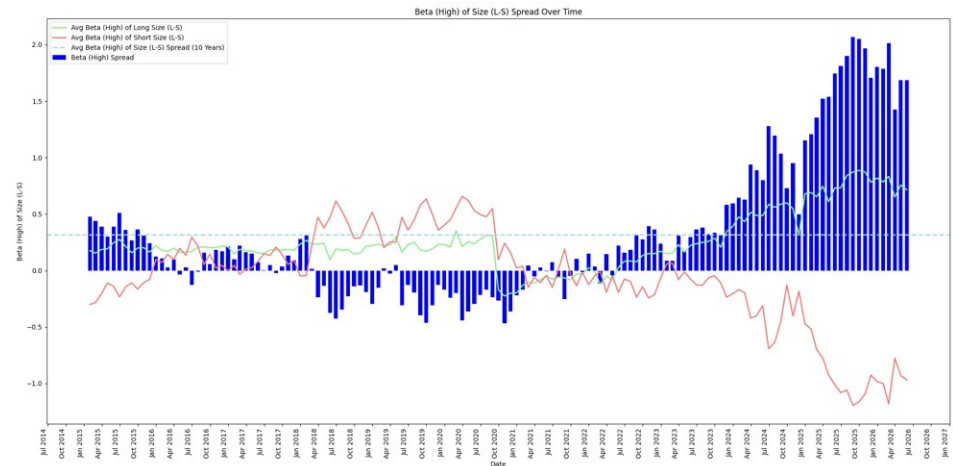


Source: J.P. Morgan

There was no particularly notable move in the risk spread for **Size (L-S)**, although the factor remains visibly tilted toward high beta.

Figure 20: Beta Spread of Size (Large vs. SMid caps)

The Y axis is Beta that is Z-Scored – the higher the Z-score, the higher the L/S portfolio is on Beta.

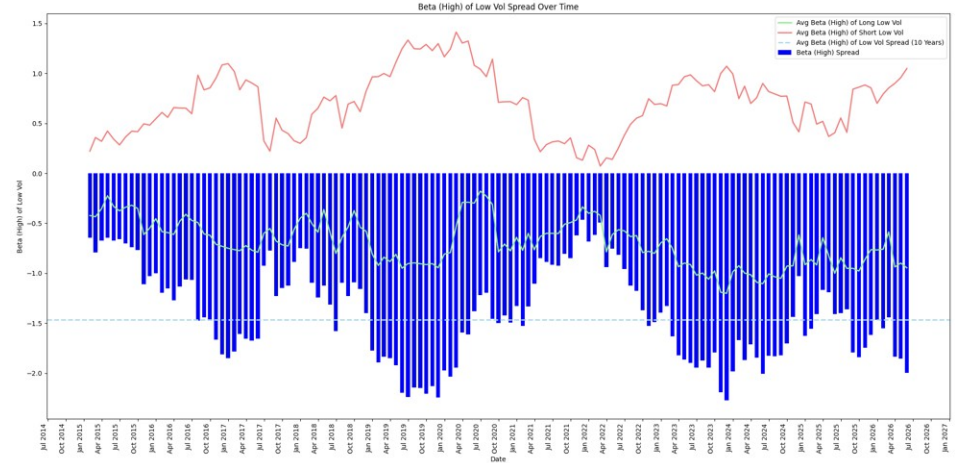


Source: J.P. Morgan

Low Vol's risk spread declined further relative to its 10-year average. Its tilt toward low beta is now around the strongest level in roughly two years.

Figure 21: Beta Spread of Low Vol (Low vs. High Volatility)

The Y axis is Beta that is Z-Scored – the higher the Z-score, the higher the L/S portfolio is on Beta.

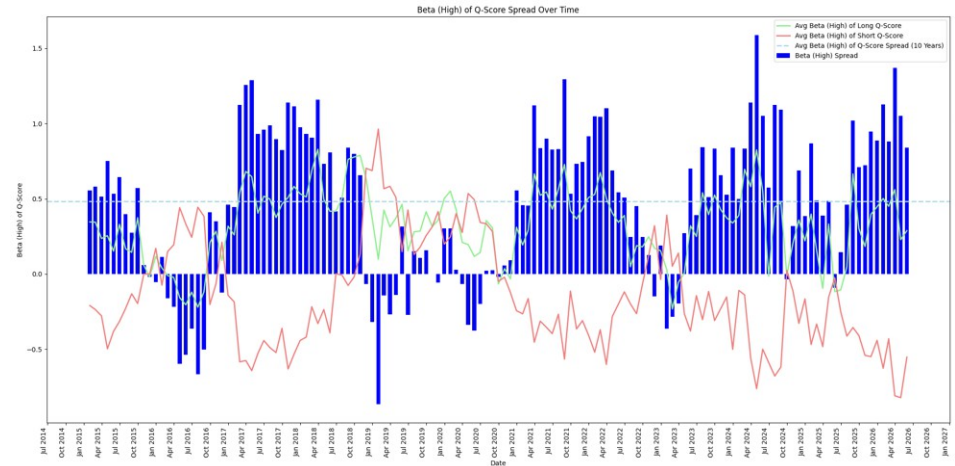


Source: J.P. Morgan

Q-score's risk spread declined slightly relative to its 10-year average. On a smoothed basis, however, it remains somewhat tilted toward high beta.

Figure 22: Beta Spread of Q-scores (Multi-factor model)

The Y axis is Beta that is Z-Scored – the higher the Z-score, the higher the L/S portfolio is on Beta.



Source: J.P. Morgan

Sector-specific factor performance

Below we summarize major factor returns by sector in May.

At the overall market level, Momentum was the best-performing factor in May. By sector, Information Technology was the main driver, followed by Communication Services. These sectors included names that benefited from the AI boom. Size, which also outperformed, showed notable overlap with Momentum at the sector level.

On the other hand, Low Vol was the worst-performing factor across the market. Excluding Q-score, profitability-related styles such as ROE and Quality also performed poorly. Against a backdrop of inflation and rising JGB yields, defensive and high-valuation names continued to weigh on performance. Despite elevated long-term JGB yields, Value clearly lagged Momentum.

Figure 23: Sector-specific Factor Performance for Japan for May

Deciles for MXJP, Quintiles for the Sectors. Monthly L/S portfolio performance: %

Factor	JP	Communicati on Services	Consumer Discretionary	Consumer Staples	Energy	Financials	Health Care	Industrials	Information Technology	Materials	Real Estate	Utilities
Momentum	6.4%	10.7%	4.1%	-1.0%	-16.9%	2.1%	-12.4%	-4.9%	19.6%	-0.7%	-7.8%	5.9%
Size (L-S)	6.3%	19.8%	7.4%	3.3%	-16.9%	6.7%	2.1%	-0.4%	20.5%	-14.7%	-10.7%	-14.3%
Beta (High)	6.2%	11.2%	7.6%	0.3%	12.0%	2.7%	-2.7%	7.3%	13.6%	-9.6%	-7.7%	5.3%
Earnings Growth	3.7%	-18.5%	1.3%	-5.9%	12.0%	5.9%	-3.9%	8.3%	6.7%	-12.1%	6.0%	9.0%
Price to Book	0.8%	10.7%	3.3%	-0.9%	4.8%	-3.3%	-0.5%	3.6%	4.4%	7.5%	1.4%	5.3%
Earnings Yield	-2.3%	-11.8%	-1.6%	6.9%	16.9%	-4.4%	11.4%	5.8%	-14.6%	3.6%	-2.0%	5.3%
Div Yield	-5.9%	-13.1%	-0.3%	6.9%	16.9%	-4.5%	-3.7%	2.5%	-4.6%	8.2%	10.4%	5.3%
ROE	-8.9%	-11.2%	-2.9%	7.7%	-12.0%	-0.8%	-3.8%	-2.9%	-33.5%	-6.8%	-2.0%	-14.9%
JPM Quality	-10.3%	-13.9%	-6.5%	7.1%	-16.9%	-0.3%	-3.1%	2.8%	-32.8%	1.1%	-2.0%	5.9%
Q-Score	-10.5%	-10.5%	2.9%	0.6%	-16.9%	-1.6%	-6.9%	-7.2%	-6.3%	-9.4%	5.3%	6.6%
Low Vol	-11.1%	-8.9%	-8.3%	6.1%	16.9%	-5.5%	6.4%	4.0%	-20.1%	-0.4%	2.0%	8.3%

Source: J.P. Morgan

A closer look at momentum

Finally, we review the details of the Momentum portfolio as of the end of May. Momentum has been particularly strong in the Japanese market. Given that this trend began around the end of last year, we believe the Momentum effect is anchored by two themes: the AI boom and expectations for the Takaichi administration's economic policy agenda. To assess the degree of divergence between expectations and fundamentals, it is useful to examine the risk characteristics of the Momentum portfolio.

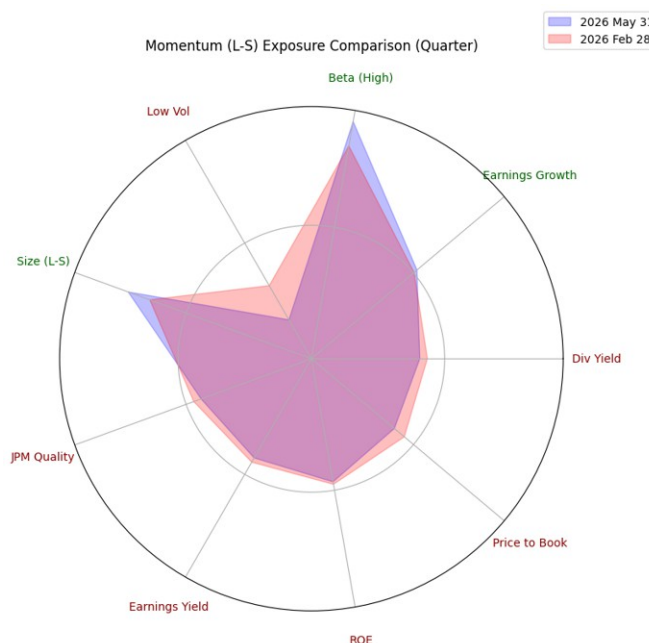
In May, the Momentum portfolio became even more tilted toward Beta and Large Cap compared with one quarter earlier, at the end of February. Conversely, exposure to P/B Value and Low Vol declined. In the May AI trade, some defensive value names appear to have served as funding shorts, while large-cap and high-beta names became the main long exposures.

From a valuation spread perspective, Momentum remained expensive versus the prior month. In terms of size spread, Momentum's tilt toward large caps widened. The quality spread declined, indicating a tilt toward lower quality. The risk spread shows that the Momentum portfolio's Beta exposure remains elevated. As concentration in AI semiconductors continues, Momentum has increasingly converged toward the characteristics of these sectors.

Our base case remains that Momentum is overheated. However, given the strength of the ongoing AI boom, we tactically believe that maintaining a selective overweight remains appropriate for now.

Figure 24: Exposure Changes in Momentum Long/Short Portfolio Over the Past 3 Months

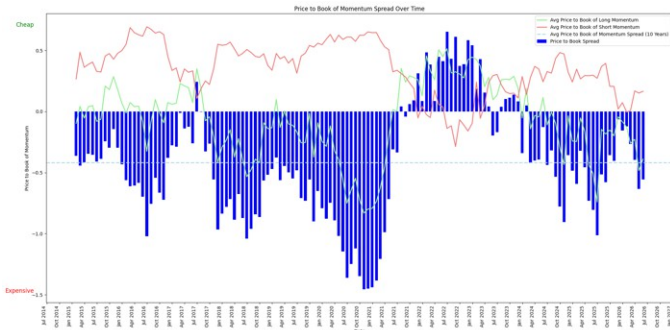
Exposures of the long-short momentum for MSCI Japan (Decile, Sector Neutralized)



Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 25: P/B Spread of Momentum

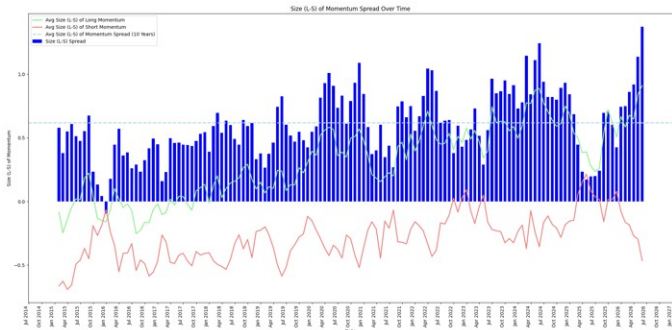
The Y axis is P/B that is Z-Scored and flipped – the higher the Z-score, the cheaper the Momentum portfolio is on P/B.



Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 26: Size Spread of Momentum

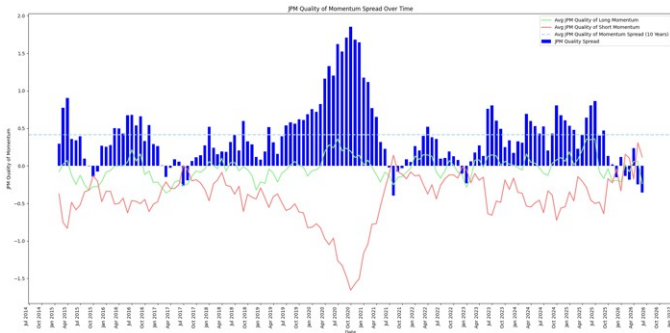
The Y axis is Size (L-S) that is Z-Scored – the higher the Z-score, the higher the Momentum portfolio is on Size.



Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 27: Quality Spread of Momentum

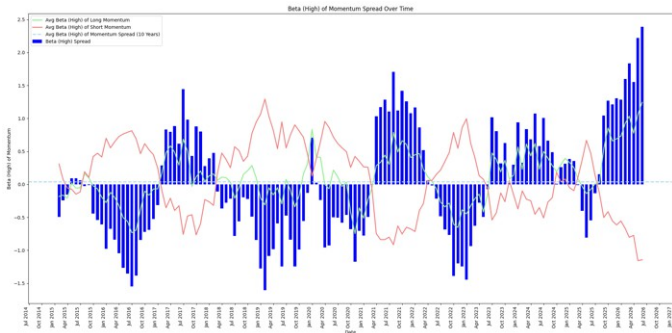
The Y axis is Quality that is Z-Scored – the higher the Z-score, the higher the Momentum portfolio is on Quality



Source: J.P. Morgan

Figure 28: Beta Spread of Momentum

The Y axis is Beta that is Z-Scored – the higher the Z-score, the higher the Momentum portfolio is on Beta



Source: J.P. Morgan

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